PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep CJ-5

1955–1983 · CJ-5 · Renegade · Golden Eagle

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Frame first**
  Check the whole frame for rust and cracks, especially at the suspension and steering mounts. Jeep-CJ.com flags the front and rear shackle mounts, the area behind the rear wheels and the six body mounts. Mud blocks the drain holes in boxed frames. Hagerty adds the outriggers, which usually rot first.
- [ ] **Steering box mount**
  Boxed frames (1976 on) often crack around the steering box, especially with a lift and big tires. Look for cracks, fresh welds and a box that moves when someone turns the wheel.
- [ ] **The tub**
  Check the rockers, rear corners, wheel wells, under the roll bar and the floor. Hagerty adds the tops of the inner and outer wheel tubs, the tailgate and the windscreen-to-scuttle joint. Jeep-CJ.com's warning: patches welded over rust become rust. Knock on panels to find filler.
- [ ] **Windshield frame**
  Fold the windshield forward and check the bottom of the frame, the hinges and the screw holes. Failed cowl and tailgate gaskets trap water and rot the metal around them.
- [ ] **Which engine**
  Hagerty recommends the 232 or 258 six for smooth power and lower running costs than the V8. Jeep-CJ.com says to avoid the 1980–83 Iron Duke. On any engine, look for start-up smoke, rattles and oil or coolant leaks.
- [ ] **Gearbox and transfer case**
  Hagerty calls the T-14 three-speed strong and longer-lasting than the later four-speeds, and Jeep-CJ.com rates the T-18 four-speed as the best transmission ever put in a CJ. Check gear-driven transfer cases for leaks and low oil. Test 4WD in high and low range on gravel.
- [ ] **Wiring and ignition**
  Hagerty calls ignition the weak point, especially on AMC engines. Be wary of duct-tape splices, wire nuts, Scotch-locks and foil-wrapped fuses. Jeep-CJ.com puts it bluntly: grounding failure is directly proportional to rust.
- [ ] **Buy a stock one**
  Jeep-CJ.com says project Jeeps and heavily built trail rigs are generally poor buys and recommends mostly stock trucks. Keep the emissions parts if you can. In some states removing them is illegal.

YEARS TO KNOW

1965	SWEET SPOT	Buick-designed 225 cu in Dauntless V6 (155 hp) becomes optional; by 1968 about 75% of CJ-5s have it. Jeep-CJ.com calls the 1966–71 Dauntless desirable, strong and reliable. 'Jeep CJ-5' replaces 'Willys' after 1964

1972	SWEET SPOT	AMC 232/258 sixes and optional 304 V8; wheelbase stretched 2.5 in to 83.5 in, nose 5 in longer, open-knuckle Dana 30 front, fuel tank behind the rear axle. Hagerty's pick is an AMC-era 232 or 258 six from 1972 on

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Headlight dimmer switch**
  1972 · NHTSA 72V-086
- ☐ **Brake master cylinder**
  1972 · NHTSA 72V-173
- ☐ **Front leaf-spring shackle**
  1974 · NHTSA 74V-157
- ☐ **Steering gear**
  1976 · NHTSA 76V-034
- ☐ **Electronic ignition wire connectors**
  1975–1976 · NHTSA 78V-065
- ☐ **Transmission adapter-plate seal**
  1976–1978 · NHTSA 78V-039
- ☐ **Intermediate steering-shaft coupling**
  1978 · NHTSA 78V-049
- ☐ **Tie-rod adjuster clamp bolts**
  1979 · NHTSA 78V-243
- ☐ **Transmission-to-transfer-case gasket**
  1979 · NHTSA 79V-070
- ☐ **Rear seat-belt buckles missing**
  1981 · NHTSA 80V-158

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Early vs late body**
  1955–75: 81 in wheelbase (83.5 in from 1972), 59 in windshield, windshield retainer welded on, windshield at 90° to the hood, no factory door hinges. 1976–83: 55 in sloped windshield with screw-on retainer, factory roll bar and door hinges, 83.5 in wheelbase, about 71.5 in from door hinge to the rear of the tub.
- ☐ **CJ-5 vs CJ-6 vs DJ-5**
  A CJ-6 is the same Jeep with a longer rear tub (101 in wheelbase to 1971, then 103.5 in per Wikipedia; Quadratec says 103 in). DJ-5 Dispatchers are two-wheel-drive postal Jeeps, so check for a front driveshaft and driven front axle.
- ☐ **VIN format**
  1971–80 CJs use a 13-character Jeep VIN; 1981–83 trucks use the 17-character federal VIN, where characters 6–7 read 85 for a CJ-5, the 4th character is the engine (B = 151 four, C = 258 six, H = 304 V8) and the 10th the model year (B = 1981, C = 1982, D = 1983).
- ☐ **VIN plate vs frame**
  The main VIN tag is riveted to the driver's side firewall; compare it with the partial VIN stamped on the passenger-side frame rail above the rear wheel. A mismatch can mean a swapped tub or salvage history.
- ☐ **Real Renegades**
  From 1972 the Renegade package meant the 304 V8, alloy wheels and a Trac-Lok rear. A six-cylinder 'Renegade' with steel wheels is either re-engined or wearing borrowed stripes.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/cj-5/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks